

Family **Thamnophilidae****Antbirds**

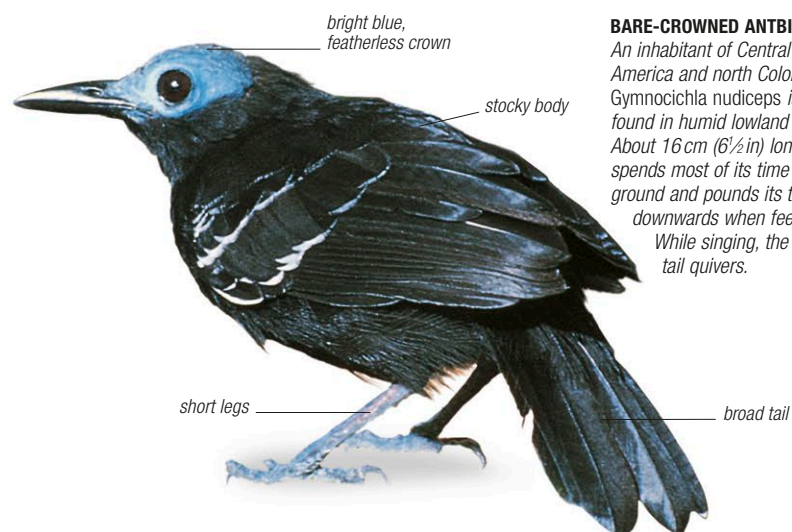
Length 3¼–14 in (8–36 cm)

Species 235



A high diversity of antbirds—including ant-shrikes, ant-wrens, and ant-vireos—live in the American tropics, reaching peak diversity in Andean and Amazonian forests. These are largely tree-dwelling birds that get their names from the tendency of certain species to follow swarms of army ants, snatching the small

animals flushed out. Many antbirds have long claws for clinging to vertical saplings as they wait for prey. Few habitually forage on the ground—most snatching insects from foliage. Although otherwise secretive in dense vegetation, antbirds often betray their presence by their whistling or chattering calls. Most members of the family are sexually dimorphic: males are generally gray, black, or white; females are brown with striking patterns that vary from species to species. A few—such as certain ant-shrikes—have crests. Those that have been studied seem to mate for life and most build a simple cup nest in a tree fork in which they lay 2, rarely, 3 eggs.



BARE-CROWNED ANTIBIRD
*An inhabitant of Central America and north Colombia, *Gymnocichla nudiceps* is found in humid lowland forest. About 16 cm (6½ in) long, it spends most of its time on the ground and pounds its tail downwards when feeding. While singing, the male's tail quivers.*

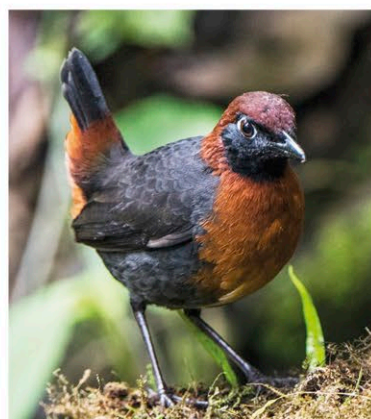
Family **Formicariidae****Antthrushes**

Length 4–8 in (10–20 cm)

Species 12



Antthrushes are small, strong-footed, short-tailed birds that walk on the forest floor, in ones or twos or gathering around swarms of army ants. They specialize in feeding on ants and are the most terrestrial of the various “antbirds.” Antthrushes lay white eggs in small, leaf-lined tree cavities. They have loud, distinctive, whistling calls.



RUFOUS-BREADED ANTTHRUSH
*This typical antthrush, *Formicarius rufpectus*, of the northern Andes and Costa Rica is hard to find in dark forest, where its characteristic rufous breast and undertail patch can be difficult to see.*

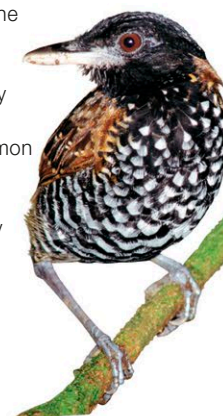
Family **Conopophagidae****Gnateaters**

Length 4–8 in (10–20 cm)

Species 11



These small, short-tailed, rather long-legged birds of South and Central America inhabit dark, shady, and humid forest floors, some in dense thickets, making them difficult to see well. In Brazil, some species spread into drier places. They are insectivorous, some species feeding on the ground while others glean insects from low-level foliage and branches. The rufous gnateater *Conopophaga lineata* is typically elusive but one of the more common and relatively more easily seen species, typically dropping to the ground from a low perch to catch an insect.



BLACK-CROWNED ANTPITTA
Pittasoma michleri is larger and more strikingly colored than most other gnateaters. It follows army ants or forays in the forest understory.

Family **Grallariidae****Antpittas**

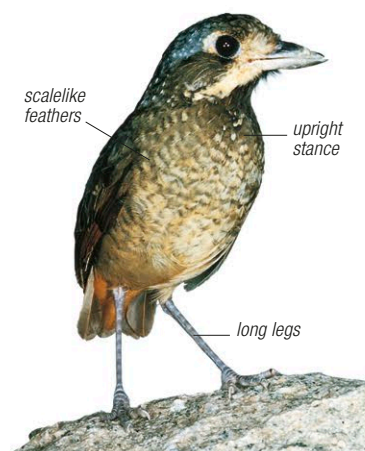
Length 4–9 in (10–22 cm)

Species 53

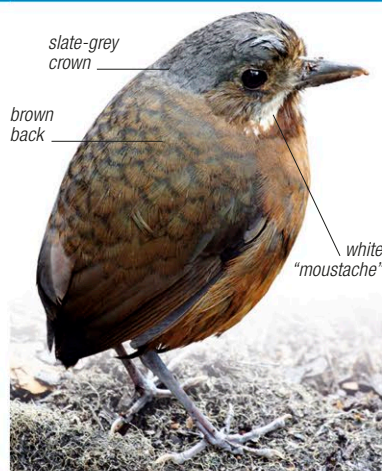


More often heard than seen, these strong-legged, stubby-tailed birds used to be classified in the same family as

ant-birds (Thamnophilidae), but they may be more closely related to ovenbirds (see opposite) and tapaculos (see right). Sexes are alike: both cryptically patterned in browns and grays. They spend more time on the ground than true ant-birds, where they move by hopping and feed on invertebrates. The related antthrushes (Formicariidae)—which walk, rather than hop—were formerly classified with antbirds, too.



VARIEGATED ANTPITTA
Grallaria varia, 8 in (20 cm) in length, has the long legs and short tail typical of the antpittas. It is found in Guyana, Surinam, French Guiana, and Brazil. This bird flicks leaves aside on the forest floor to probe for earthworms and insects.



MOUSTACHED ANTPITTA
*Many antpittas—such as the *Grallaria alleni* from Colombia and Ecuador—are poorly known. It is a skulking bird that lives in dense undergrowth in humid montane forests on the slopes of the Andes.*

JOCOTOCO ANTPITTA
*Discovered in 1997 in southern Ecuador—and still known from only 5 locations—*Grallaria ridgelyi* is a large, boldly patterned antpitta. Like other antpitta species, it has strong legs for hopping about on the ground, where it is known to feed on insects and their larvae, worms, and millipedes. It has only been found in moss-covered montane bamboo forests beside streams, a perpetually wet habitat that is under threat because of deforestation. Its already low population size is undoubtedly in decline because of this.*

Family **Rhinocryptidae****Tapaculos**

Length 4¼–10 in (11–25 cm)

Species 59



Found principally in southern South America, tapaculos have a distinctive, movable flap of skin covering the nostril. They are long-legged, mainly ground-dwelling birds that feed on invertebrates. Their short, rounded wings and long tails allow them to fly only briefly and weakly. Secretive and rarely seen, tapaculos are identified by their loud calls. They generally build their nest in a hole or crevice at ground level, or in a burrow that they dig themselves, and lay 2–4 white eggs.



CHUCAO TAPACULO
Scelorchilus rubecula superficially resembles a European robin. It has a striped black and white belly, and is 7½ in (19 cm) long. It is found in south Chilean temperate forest, including bamboo thickets.